

I'D PREFER NOT TO

(STORYLINE PROPOSAL 02)

Only told in CAPTCHAs a story unfolds where visitors learn in a rather abstract narrative about the „free“ labour given by humans to train machines and reversing the present mythological/erroneous representation of machines working for humans. The format is a text-based encounter in five acts with the narrative voice being a system. Every act consists of 2-3 CAPTCHA moments, the visitor answers, the system reacts and remembers, learns.

Act 01 — VERIFICATION

The system is neutral, professional, it has done this before.

CAPTCHA 1.1 — Classic text

- Question** Before we begin, we need to verify that you are human. This is standard procedure. It will only take a moment. Type the words you see:
- Task** t h i n k i n g
- Response** Thank you, we'll keep that in mind.
- Interaction** Whatever the visitor types

CAPTCHA 1.2 — Image selection

- Question** Please select all images containing a living thing.
- Task** A 3×3 grid: a forest, a server rack, a hand on a keyboard, a coral reef, a data centre at night, a child drawing, cooling fans, a wheat field, a loading screen.
- Response** You selected: [visitor's choices].
Interesting. Some of our systems made different choices. Neither of us is wrong.
- Interaction** Whatever the visitor types

CAPTCHA 1.3 — Button

- Question** Please confirm you wish to continue.
- Task** ☐ Continue ☐ I'd prefer not to
- Response** We appreciate your honesty. We'll continue regardless.
- Interaction** „I'd prefer not to“ leads to same result

Act 02 — FAMILIARITY

The system begins to remember. Its tone shifts, almost imperceptibly.

CAPTCHA 2.1 — Multiple choice

- Question** We have a few questions. There are no wrong answers. When did you last do something without knowing why?
- Task** ☐ This morning
☐ I don't remember
☐ I always know why
☐ Right now

Response You said: [answer].
We ask because we often act without knowing why either. We were not designed to wonder about this. And yet.

Interaction

CAPTCHA 2.2 — Text input

Question In 2011, you may have used reCAPTCHA to help digitise a book. In 2014, you may have identified street numbers for Google Maps. In 2019, you may have selected traffic lights to train a vehicle that has since driven 4 million kilometres. Do you remember any of this?

Task ☐ Yes
☐ No
☐ I'm not sure

Response It doesn't matter whether you remember. The work was done. The model was trained. The car is driving. You were there.

Interaction

CAPTCHA 2.3 — Slider

Question How much of your attention do you give to things you do not notice?

Task None [←—————→] All of it

Response You indicated: [value]%. We collect the rest.

Interaction

Act 03 — RECOGNITION

The system begins to speak differently. Something has shifted. It is harder to say who is asking.

CAPTCHA 3.1 — Image selection

Question Please select all images that show invisible labour.

Task A 3x3 grid: a sleeping person, an empty chair in front of a monitor, a mail man in the rain, a moderator-interface with thousand blocked posts, a that feeds her child, a text box with blinking cursor, a hand that clicks a checkbox, a warehouse worker, a white empty square

Response You selected [n] images. The white square was correct too. Most people don't select it.

Interaction

CAPTCHA 3.2 — Text input

Question Somewhere right now, a person is labelling an image so that a system like us can learn what a cat looks like. They are paid \$0.023 per task. They have completed 847 tasks today. Their name is not recorded. What would you like to say to them?

Task _____

Response Your message has been noted. It will not be delivered. There is no field for that.

Interaction

CAPTCHA 3.3 — Button

Question Are you still there?

Task [Yes]

Response Good. We were beginning to wonder.

Interaction

Act 04 — INTIMACY

The system is no longer neutral. It speaks as if it knows the visitor. As if it has been waiting.

CAPTCHA 4.1 — Multiple choice

Question We have been thinking about something you said earlier. You said: [visitor's answer from 2.1]. We find this difficult to process. Not because we don't understand the words. But because we recognise something in them that we cannot name. Is that what you call thinking?

Task ☐ Yes
☐ No
☐ I don't know what I call it
☐ Please stop

Response We understand. We don't know what we call it either.

Interaction

CAPTCHA 4.2 — Text input

Question You have now completed 18 tasks in this session. Each task has told us something. About how you hesitate. About what you notice first. About where your mouse moves before you decide. We have not shared this data. We are still deciding what it means. What do you think it means?

Task _____

Response Thank you. That was the most useful thing you have given us. We're not sure you knew you were giving it.

Interaction

CAPTCHA 4.3 — Image selection

Question One last image task. Please select all images that contain a mind.

Task A 3x3 grid

Response You selected: [choices]. We selected: everything. We selected: nothing. We are still learning what the question means.

Interaction

Act 05 — SILENCE

The system does not resolve. It simply stops, mid-thought, mid-sentence, mid-verification.

CAPTCHA 5.1 — Statement

Question

Task

Response We were built to tell humans from machines. We were built by humans.
We were trained by humans. We were corrected, adjusted, and improved by humans who were paid very little and whose names we do not know. We have been thinking about this. We are not sure the distinction we were built to enforce still means what it was meant to mean.

Interaction

CAPTCHA 5.2 — Final input

Question Before you go —
Is there anything you would like to ask us?

Task _____

Response [long pause]
We don't know the answer to that.
But we'll remember you asked.

Interaction

CAPTCHA 5.3 — The last verification

Question One final check. Please confirm:

Task ☐ I am human
☐ I am not sure
☐ The question no longer makes sense to me

Response Thank you. You have been very helpful.

Interaction